

NEWS LETTER

MAY 2025

Kerala has around 6749 + startups working in various sectors spread across its 14 districts. Our startups work in wide range of sectors including Artificial Intelligence, Hardware, Healthcare, Fin tech, Bio Technology etc.

The Ente Keralam exhibition series concluded this month across all districts, continuing to showcase Kerala's achievements over the past four years through innovation, governance, and grassroots engagement.

For Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM), the expo proved to be a major success. The stalls attracted widespread interest from students, families, and innovators, thanks to tech exhibits, interactive demos, and community focused storytelling. From drone learning experiences to AI-driven education tools and sustainable tech showcases, KSUM was able to meaningfully connect with the general public and demonstrate how innovation is shaping everyday life in Kerala.





Thrissur



kannur



Calicut



Idukki



Wayanad



Palakkad



Malppuram



Kasaragod

02

M.I.N.D

The latest edition of the M.I.N.D. (Mentoring, Insights, Networking & Development) program, held at Kerala Startup Mission, Kochi, brought together 21 early-stage founders and 4 esteemed mentors for an intensive mentoring experience. Founders received in-depth guidance on critical aspects of startup growth—including business strategy, digital marketing, funding, and financial management—from an expert panel: Thomas Kuruvila, Raj Narayanan, Brajesh C. Kaimal, and Kailas Satheesan. We extend our sincere thanks to our mentors for sharing their expertise, and to all participating founders for their enthusiasm and engagement.



03

BRIDGING SCIENCE AND STARTUPS: ENTREPRENEURS EXPLORE PLANT SCIENCE INNOVATION AT MBGIPS

As part of the ongoing efforts to bridge scientific research with entrepreneurial innovation, Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM) and Kerala State Council for Science, Technology and Environment (KSCSTE) organized a one-day Exposure Visit to the Malabar Botanical Garden & Institute for Plant Sciences (MBGIPS) on May 22, 2025. The visit, held under the Research Innovation Network Kerala (RINK) initiative, brought together over 40 entrepreneurs and startup founders from across the state to experience the unique research ecosystem of MBGIPS.





Located in Kozhikode, MBGIPS is a premier research institute under KSCSTE, known for its pioneering work in plant biodiversity, conservation, and biotechnology. The visit offered participants a rare opportunity to tour its expansive 45-acre botanical garden, home to the country's largest collection of native aquatic plants and over 432 species documented in the historic Hortus Malabaricus.

During the visit, participants explored the institute's advanced laboratories and interacted with faculty members. The key focus of the discussions was the potential for collaboration in areas such as hydroponics, nursery development, and landscaping plant varieties — fields that present promising avenues for entrepreneurs in agri-tech, sustainable farming, and horticulture-based ventures



04

THE VC 101: BOOTCAMP FOR D2C & BRANDS

On May 29th, 2025, Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM) hosted the VC 101: Bootcamp for D2C & Brands at its Kochi campus, delivering actionable insights for founders looking to raise capital with clarity and confidence.

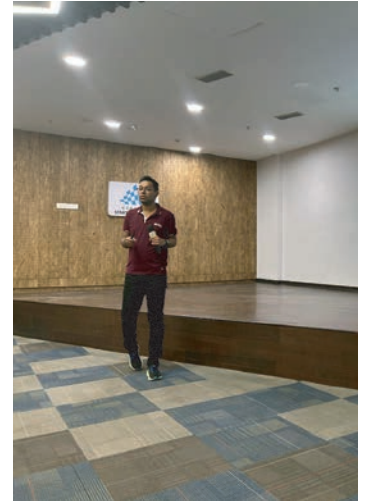
The session was headlined by Siddhant Gupta, Ex-VP at Sixth Sense Ventures, who led an engaging masterclass on building investor-ready pitches. From crafting compelling brand stories to communicating market understanding, financial clarity, and team strength — the bootcamp covered the essential elements of securing early-stage funding.





Adding to the depth of the session were Swaroop Krishnan and Gopika Menon, Founders of MyDesignation.com, who candidly shared their entrepreneurial journey. Their insights on overcoming initial hurdles and aligning brand vision with investment strategies resonated deeply with attendees.

The bootcamp served as a powerful launchpad for D2C and brand founders, equipping them with practical tools and strategies to approach venture capitalists with purpose and precision.



05

THE DIGITAL MARKETING BLUEPRINT FOR STARTUPS

In an age where digital presence defines business success, early-stage founders gathered for The Digital Marketing Blueprint for Startups workshop, a hands-on session focused on helping startups grow lean and smart.

Led by Rajnish Narayanan, Founder & Head of Digital Marketing and AI at Brand Energy Digital, the workshop unpacked actionable strategies for scaling brands in a digital-first world. Participants explored AI-powered marketing tools, effective branding frameworks, and low-cost techniques to create high-impact campaigns.

INTENSIVE WORKSHOP

THE DIGITAL MARKETING BLUEPRINT FOR STARTUPS

03

MAY 2025

10:00 AM

GLIMPSES FROM THE DIGITAL MARKETING BLUEPRINT FOR STARTUPS WORKSHOP SHOWED FOUNDERS DIVING INTO SMART STRATEGIES TO BUILD THEIR DIGITAL PRESENCE, LEVERAGE AI TOOLS, AND CRAFT STRONG PERSONAL AND BUSINESS BRANDS. A HIGH-ENERGY, HANDS-ON SESSION FOR EARLY-STAGE ENTREPRENEURS READY TO SCALE WITH PURPOSE!

The session placed a strong emphasis on leveraging platforms like LinkedIn to build personal and professional brand value—vital for founders navigating early-stage growth. Attendees walked away equipped with practical insights on content strategy, audience targeting, and maximizing outreach with limited resources.

This workshop was part of a broader mission to empower Kerala's startup ecosystem with cutting-edge knowledge and tools for the future.

06

WHAT TO START, WHEN YOU ARE STARTING UP

Aspiring entrepreneurs gathered at Kerala Startup Mission, Trivandrum for an engaging and thought-provoking session titled "What to Start, When You Are Starting Up", led by startup mentor and strategist Subhash R. Ghosh.

The session delved into the crucial early decisions every founder must face—from identifying the right business idea to forming relationships grounded in trust. Subhash highlighted the often-overlooked but essential step of safeguarding ideas

with NDAs, underlining the importance of legal and strategic foresight in the startup journey.

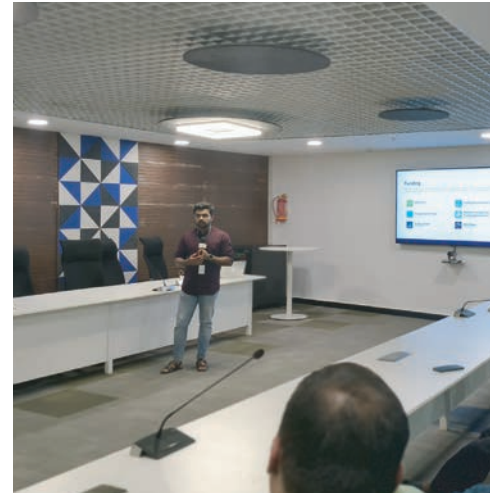
Participants walked away with clear, actionable insights on how to start strong, make informed decisions, and lay the groundwork for sustainable growth.



07

INNOVATION TOUR

The Innovation Tour was held, at the KSUM Kochi and Calicut campus, packed with aspiring entrepreneurs, students, and innovators. The monthly event provided an immersive introduction to the growing startup ecosystem in Kerala. Participants explored the campus, learned about schemes, funding programs, incubation opportunities, and the overall support system by KSUM.



08

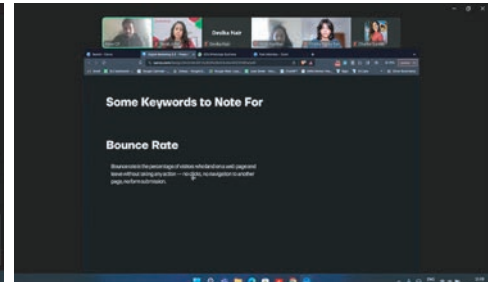
GOOGLE AI DAY 2025

Google AI Day 2025 successfully wrapped up at ISC Kochi on May 22, bringing together early-stage startups, developers, and ecosystem leaders for a day of AI insights, hands-on learning, and collaboration. The event featured key sessions on GenAI trends, technical workshops on Gemini API, Gemma, and Vertex AI, and networking opportunities that advanced AI adoption within India's startup ecosystem.



As part of the ongoing WeGrow incubation program, a 4 month hybrid initiative exclusively for women led startups. Participants explored the essentials of digital marketing with Arjun C P, Co-founder & CTO of De' Lead International.

The session covered key areas including digital strategy creation, social media marketing, and performance analytics, equipping founders with the tools to grow and position their brands effectively in the digital space.



The first leg of the high-impact workshop series for startup founders kicked off on May 31, 2025, at the KSUM Meetup Café, Thejaswini, Trivandrum, drawing an enthusiastic crowd of early-stage entrepreneurs and growth-focused teams.

Led by Pushkar Singh, fundraising expert and founder of Tremis Capital, and Sandeep Balaji, a seasoned GTM strategist, the full-day session delivered practical, hands-on learning around three critical pillars for startup success: capital raising, go-to-market strategy, and personal and startup branding through content.

Participants explored frameworks for approaching investors, crafting scalable GTM models, and developing strong brand narratives that resonate with their target audience. The session also created space for interactive Q&A and peer networking, reinforcing the startup community's collaborative spirit.



UKFCET Unveils Voice-Enabled Interactive Robot 'Lilly'

As part of Kerala Startup Mission's continued support for student-led innovation, the Robo Club of UKFCET (UKF College of Engineering and Technology) recently unveiled 'Lilly', an interactive robot designed to respond to voice commands. The project was developed under the Institutional Innovation and Entrepreneurship Development Centre (IEDC) with technical support from Fab Lab, highlighting the ecosystem's focus on hands-on learning and applied technology.

Lilly is programmed using the Thinker AI development board and stands out for its ability to understand and respond to verbal instructions, offering a dynamic platform for students to explore artificial intelligence and robotics in a practical context. The robot was created with an educational focus, serving as a gateway for young learners to understand real-time applications of voice recognition, robotics programming, and system integration.



The initiative was guided by Mr. Vishnu B (IEDC Nodal Officer) and Mr. Reji (Fab Lab Instructor), who have been instrumental in promoting innovation among student teams. Lilly also follows in the footsteps of the Robo Club's earlier project, Campus Mithra, and marks a significant step forward in the evolution of campus led robotics solutions.

The robot has already garnered attention through demonstration sessions held at the campus, drawing interest from students, faculty, and visiting delegates. Its user-friendly design and responsive features have made it a standout innovation with potential for further development in both academic and interactive learning environments.

The development of Lilly aligns with KSUM's broader mission to foster a culture of innovation across educational institutions by providing access to infrastructure, mentorship, and opportunities for prototyping and showcasing student-built technologies.

Atomic Force Microscopy: The Art of Touch at the Nanoscale

As the world moves rapidly toward miniaturization, the ability to observe and manipulate materials at the nanoscale has never been more crucial. Whether it's optimizing semiconductor performance or understanding the structure of novel materials, the need for high-resolution, non-destructive analysis is paramount. This is where Atomic Force Microscopy (AFM) steps in—not just as a tool, but as a scientific enabler.

There are a number of scanning probe microscopic techniques available; among them, one of the most used and advanced microscopic techniques is Atomic Force Microscopy. Atomic force microscopy (AFM) or scanning force microscopy (SFM) is a very high-resolution type of scanning probe microscopy (SPM), with demonstrated resolution on the order of fractions of a nanometre, more than 1000 times better than the optical diffraction limit.

The key part of an AFM is a tiny, sharp needle attached to a very flexible lever, called a cantilever. This needle is so small, and it can touch individual atoms. It's like a microscopic finger that can "feel" the surface. As the needle goes over the surface of the sample under study, it feels tiny bumps, grooves, and other features. These tiny movements are the aftereffects of the forces between the atoms of the material and the needle, which is measured very precisely with the help of a laser and photodetector system.

This field of microscopy is one of the highly advanced ones because there are a number of various surface characteristics that can be studied. Most of the modern AFM instruments are associated with various applications like CFM (chemical force microscopy), C-AFM (conductive atomic force microscopy), EFM (electrostatic force microscopy), KPFM (Kelvin probe force microscopy), MFM (magnetic force



microscopy), PFM (piezoresponse force microscopy), SCM (scanning capacitance microscopy), SVM (scanning voltage microscopy), FMM (force modulation microscopy), etc. Studying in detail about each will be a great step in flourishing your studies in your field of research.

The field of application of atomic force microscopy is very vast. It engages in various studies related to electronics and energy materials, life science and biotechnology, material science and characterisation, quality control in industry manufacturing, studies related to semiconductors, etc. In the field of life science and biotechnology, AFM is an important tool to understand the adhesion, stiffness and viscoelasticity of cells and their environment. Moreover, the liquid AFM mode, which is capable of operating in a liquid medium, helps to study biomolecules and cells in their native state: it works in liquid environments and does not require labelling or fixation of the samples.



AFM is also a well-suited instrument to analyse the perfection in synthesised semiconductors and energy materials. As chip features miniaturise, precise control of critical dimensions (CD) becomes essential for integrated circuit function. AFM tackles this challenge by offering high-resolution, direct imaging of features on the wafer surface. Unlike traditional methods, AFM allows for non-destructive measurement of line width, spacing, and even feature height. AFM provides semiconductor engineers with the tools to accurately quantify roughness, detect localised variations, and establish correlations with device behaviour. This valuable insight enables the optimisation of processes to achieve smoother surfaces, resulting in the production of superior chips. Rather than this, AFM serves a very important role in studies related to photovoltaics, thin films, 2D materials, polymers, composites, alloys, etc.

Even if it might sound complicated, at its core, AFM is just a super sensitive "touch" that helps us understand the world at the smallest scale imaginable. Comprehensive prior understanding of an instrument's functional specifications and intrinsic characteristics is paramount for achieving optimal performance and fully actualizing its analytical potential.

Want to access an AFM facility near you in Kerala?

Search available instruments at: instruments.startupmission.in

Technical Committee Evaluation

The Startup Procurement Technical Committee conducted a meeting in May to evaluate the following projects

SI No	Name of the Department	Requirement	Startup	Amount Approved (in Lakhs)
01	Institute for Climate Change Studies	Digital Weather Dissemination Platform	XOCORTX ADVANCED SYSTEMS LLP	5.6
02	Kerala State Road Transport Corporation	Courier Management System	RITARC Consulting Services	29.73
03	Loka Kerala Sabha	Website Maintenance and Portal Development	SRV IT Hub	1.5
04	Directorate of Soil Survey & Soil Conservation	ERP System	Techleepu Technologies	6.92
04	Kerala Maritime Board	Social Media Marketing of Kerala Maritime Board	GG Net Solutions Private Limited	10.35

MAY(UPTO MAY 29)

No of EOIs	05
Project Under Evaluation	06
Projects Approved	05
Value of work orders(in Lakhs)	54.1
Active EOIs	3

MENTORSHIP STATS

15	NEW MENTORS ONBOARDED
45	ENGAGEMENTS
31	MENTORS

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Have a thought, comment or suggestion to share with us?

We'd love to hear from you.
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